



April 26, 2023

Greetings MBSA Family,

José Rodriguez, President of Monroeville Baseball & Softball association here. With opening day approaching, I want to take a moment to introduce myself and provide some exciting updates on the state and direction of the association for our members.

I've been volunteering with MBSA since 2018, mostly as an in-house and tournament coach at the coach pitch level. For those of you who aren't familiar with our family, my wife Nia and I have two boys - River and Cash - currently in Mustang and Coach Pitch. We've lived in Monroeville for 9 years and have spent the better half of the last 5 springs, summers, and falls also living at Monroeville Park West. Please come say hello, anytime.

Former MBSA President Will Graves is a neighbor and approached me last year to gauge my interest in getting more involved. With his son Colin aging out of the league, he felt it was time to transition the MBSA board to a group with children that would be participating in MBSA programs for some time. This wasn't something I had previously considered, but I am appreciative for the opportunity and excited to serve with the rest of the board. Thanks again for the consideration Will.

Before the new MBSA board began last October, Executive Commissioner Josh Plassmeyer and I had a long discussion about priorities for the association and how we could best improve the experience for our members. In the time we've been involved, MBSA leadership has done a phenomenal job but were also vocal about some of the challenges they've faced that, if resolved, could really improve our offering.

While there are more than a few challenges and ideas, the board felt the first step was to evolve the association into a true not-for-profit community organization that engages others around our mission and vision to find more advocates, supporters, and partners to help bring the best experience we can to our members.

From where we are sitting, the most important of these partners is the Municipality of Monroeville. Their graciousness is how we have free access to some of the best facilities in all of Western PA, saving MBSA the trouble of having to raise money to build and maintain our own complex. But with that graciousness comes a balancing act between facilities use and our contribution to maintenance, upkeep, and improvements at Monroeville Park West.

In an effort to address that, the MBSA board identified some grant opportunities, leveraging our non-profit status to acquire funding that could help us support The Municipality with the maintenance and upgrades, while also improving the experience for everyone that uses MPW - completing a request for proposal (RFP) with the Pennsylvania Department of Community and Economic Development (DCED) and another with Allegheny County's Gaming Economic Development Tourism fund (GEDTF).



We are excited to announce that our proposals were accepted, with MBSA being awarded \$250,000 from the DCED and another \$100,000 from the GEDTF.

We've attached our applications and award letters for MBSA members to look through and learn more about in detail. The brief overview of this project is that the funds will be used to improve Monroeville Park West by paying for some necessary maintenance and repairs, but also upgrades to the park that include batting cages (I know!), scoreboards with LEDS, and a PA system, among others. We've named it "Project Sandlot".

We are incredibly excited about what Project Sandlot will help create for everyone that uses Monroeville Park West, but want our members to know that we're in the early stages of this process. We ask that you be patient as we work with the municipality and our funders to complete the project. It will not get done overnight, but all involved are committed to ensuring that every cent of this money is spent to accomplish exactly what we requested it for.

We also want to be clear about how these awards work: they require MBSA to pay for the work ourselves, then submit invoices for that work to our funders for reimbursement. This is a very important distinction. MBSA's bank account simply isn't \$350,000 richer than it was before these awards. Instead, the awards are currently reflected as assets on MBSA's balance sheet. You will see them as a budget line item on our financial statement and as we spend money and wait to be reimbursed, they will be reflected as receivables owed to us from the county or state. The money we're reimbursed becomes income that significantly contributes to the financial viability of the association. The long term goal is to highlight the success of this collaborative effort and all of MBSA's initiatives to identify other funders who will support projects we feel can take MBSA to the next level - things like free clinics, player development, and camps with professionals.

Anyone who would like to know more should join the board at our monthly member meetings. We will continue to provide regular updates on how Project Sandlot is progressing as part of our agenda. In the meantime, do not hesitate to reach out to us via email with questions or feedback.

It's an exciting time for baseball and softball in Monroeville, and this is just the beginning. I look forward to being with all of you and sharing more about our vision for the future of MBSA this Saturday when we kick off the 2023 Spring Season!

Best,

José Rodríguez

President

Monroeville Baseball & Softball Association